

from Genesis 1-11. And so, for the second time, we expect there to be some kind of divine judgment that confronts the sin of foolish, violent humans and stems the tide of their destructive choices. This is precisely the theme of Genesis 17.

Covenant #2 With Avraham: Sign of Circumcision

This is the longest and most complicated speech so far in the book of Genesis. Before diving into its details, it's helpful to get an overview of its main content and literary organization.

Macro Design of Genesis 17

At its most basic, the chapter is designed in a simple three-step progression.

Genesis 17:1-16

A - God's Speech to Avraham: Covenant, **Promise of Seed**, Summons to **Circumcise Every Male**

Genesis 17:17-22

B - God and Avraham Dialogue about the **Promise of Seed**

Genesis 17:23-27

A' - Avraham **Circumcises Every Male** in His House

Genesis 17:1-27 (3-Step). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 17:1-3

Speech 1, Initial Statement: Yahweh Will Make a Covenant With Avram

- a - When Avram was a son of ninety-nine years,
- b - and Yahweh became visible to Avram, and said to him
- c - "I will give **my covenant** between me and between you
- d - **I will multiply you very very much** "
- e - **And Avram fell upon his face**

Genesis 17:4-16

17:4-8

A - Speech 2, The Covenant: New Name Blessing, Royal Seed, Land

- "And Elohim spoke to him saying ..."

As for me [Yahweh] ...

My covenant is with you

No longer will your name be called Avram, but "Avraham" will be your name

I will make you a multitude of nations
I will make you fruitful, very very much
and kings will come from you

17:9-14

B - Speech 3, Sign of the Covenant: Circumcision, Cut Off Foreskin

- "And Elohim said to Avraham ..."

As for you [Avraham] ...

This is my covenant that you will keep: Circumcise every male ...

Any son of eight days will be circumcised, every male of your generations ...

The foreskin of a male that is not circumcised ... he will cut off from his people ...

17:15-16

A' - Speech 4, The Promise: New Name Blessing, Son, Royal Seed

- "And Elohim said to Avraham ..."

As for Sarai ...

Her name will not be called Sarai, but "Sarah" is her name

And I will bless her

and she will become nations

kings of peoples will be from her

Genesis 17:17-22

Yahweh's Appeal to Israel: Turn to Me and Live!

e - And Avram fell upon his face

d - "Will there be a birth for a son of one-hundred years?!"

c - "I will establish my covenant with Yitskhaq ..."

b - "I will multiply [Yishmael] very very much"

a - And he finished speaking to him, and Elohim went up from Avraham

Genesis 17:23-27

Narrative: Fulfillment of the Circumcision Command

- And Avraham took Yishmael ... everyone born of his house, every male ...
and he circumcised the flesh of their foreskin just as God said.

Genesis 17:1-27 (Detailed). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This literary organization highlights a number of key themes in the chapter.